

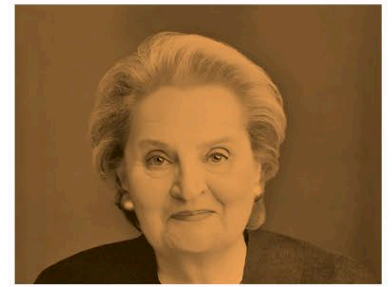
the 1950s, entire families sought new lives in cities such as Paris and Lyon. Many lived, at least at first, in filthy shanty towns around the cities because they could not get social housing. The recent crises in the Middle East have brought renewed attention to the plight of refugee women. After a period of lower global displacement levels, the 2005 invasion of Iraq by US forces marked a return to large waves of refugees. Since the start of the civil war in Syria in 2011, 12 million people have been displaced, while about 8 million have left their homes in Colombia due to civil war. Scrutinized by the modern world, these crises have brought the hardships faced by refugee women out into the open.

Protection and prevention

Refugee women often experience emotional and physical trauma when escaping oppressive conditions and finding themselves in hostile

environments. They face many challenges, including dangerous journeys across seas and borders. For example, women and children fleeing from Syria lost their lives crossing the Mediterranean Sea, while recent reports have suggested that Algerian women forced to leave the country at gunpoint have been left to die in the Sahara Desert, some of them pregnant. Due to the lack of security, sexual assault (experienced by one in five refugee women), physical abuse, and pregnancies resulting from rape are all part of life in refugee camps.

Such problems have led to the creation of organizations such as the Women's Refugee Commission, formed in 1989. This has helped to raise awareness of the challenges faced by refugee women, but there is still a long way to go to ensure that they enter a safer place than the one they left behind.



BIOGRAPHY

MADELEINE ALBRIGHT

Born in Prague in 1937, Madeleine Albright and her family were forced into exile in 1938 from her homeland of Czechoslovakia. They moved to Britain and then the US, where Albright studied politics and international relations before eventually working on the White House security council. She served as the first female Secretary of State in 1997–2001, after which she remained involved in politics as a staunch defender of both women's and refugee rights.



◀ Seeking asylum

Ethiopian women wait to receive relief from the Red Cross at the makeshift Somare refugee camp in Moyale, Kenya. Nearly 10,000 Ethiopians, over 600 of them expectant mothers, fled after soldiers attacked their villages in 2018.